The top of the pyramid gives one an adrenaline-boosted euphoria, but also a feeling of loneliness, and at times, looking down gives a scary feeling. The responsibilities increase in geometric progression along with awesome accountability. Hence, the crown is always laced with thorns. In the highest ranks, qualities and traits such as vision, foresight, compassion, being lion-hearted with moral courage to stand up for organizational interest, and loyalty to superiors, peers and juniors assume greatest significance. Keeping one's cool under extremely stressful situations becomes imperative. It is equally important to pick the best team of advisers, who are competent, sincere and loyal.

The military leadership should advise the government in a frank, forthright and professional manner. However, when a directive is received, it should be carried out to the best of our abilities. An individual's personal views do not have a place at that stage. One cannot apportion or arrogate to himself the authority to question, or worse, defy the command of the lawfully elected government of the day. The tradition of 'not to question why but to do and die' was what we grew up with. In our history we have had one unfortunate case where a service chief challenged the orders of the government and was reported to have stated that they were 'un-implementable'. The government had no option except to remove him from the service. But his action caused irreparable damage to the institution. He could have honourably resigned if he had strong reservations. That step would have earned him the respect of the rank and file. Similarly, it may be recalled that during the Korean war, a highly distinguished hero of the Second World War, General D. MacArthur, was removed from command for not being able to 'support the policies of the Administration', and recently, another US general in Afghanistan was given the marching orders for his adverse comments against government policy. Admiral Arun Prakash, a former naval chief, had said this in 1999 about officers going to court: 'it is inevitable that he (the officer) will have to show either the Service or his brother officers, or both in a poor light. The officer will also feel the need to enlist the support of bureaucrats,